The Cherokee Lottery Collection

By William Jay Smith

INTRODUCTION

In 1828 gold was discovered on Cherokee land at Dahlonega in northern Georgia, where the Cherokees for centuries had hunted. Now they grew crops, and tended lush peach orchards and rich cattle farms. But still they did not own Dahlonega. In May 1830, at Present Andrew Jackson's prodding, Congress passed the Removal Act, which set aside territory west of the Mississippi for the relocation of Indian tribes. The Indians had no choice. Eight years later, when all resistance had failed, the Cherokee joined other tribes in forced exile. Thousands died on what became known as the Trail of Tears. The devastation began with . . . The Cherokee Lottery by William Jay Smith.

The Cherokee Lottery

-- Georgia 1838and while the wheel creaked

When the Cherokees refused to leave,
the state set up a lottery
to rid them of their land:
a clumsy wooden wheel
sat poised above great black
numbers painted on bright squares –
woodpecker red and watermelon green,
wild azalea orange
and morningglory blue –
to designate the farms
that now were up for grabs:
and while the wheel creaked
slowly round, the Georgians
danced and sang:
"All we want in this creation
Is a pretty little girl
And a big plantation
Way down yonder
In the Cherokee Nation!"
and laughed until they cried.

General Winfield Scott,
blue-uniformed, bushy-browed, six-foot-three,
arrived from Washington
and addressed the Cherokees:
"May's full moon
is already on the wane,
and before another
passes, every Cherokee,
man, woman, and child,
must move along to join
their brothers in the West."

And when his troops swept in
from every quarter,
fixed bayonets flashing in the sun

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to roust them from their tables
and their beds,
the Cherokees, stripped
of everything they owned,
at last lined up to go.

White-haired Going Snake
the eighty-year-old chief,
on his pony led the way,
followed by young men on horseback.
Then the women and children,
with rustling sound
wind makes in tall dry grass,
came on, and no one spoke,
no one cried: only the dogs
howled as if they along
could voice the nation's grief
while the procession slowly wound its way
off through the tall pines
over the red clay.

At the moment they began to move,
a low rumble of distant thunder
broke directly westward
and a dark spiral cloud rose
above the horizon,
but the sun was unclouded,
the thunder rolled away,
and no rain fell.

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TRANSITION

15,000 Indian men, women and children were forced to march westward to what is now Oklahoma. Of these, an estimated 4,000 died on the brutal journey due to starvation, exhaustion, and exposure to the unforgiving elements. Smith both celebrates and mourns his own Choctaw heritage, and that of all Americans, in the haunting poem . . . The Pumpkin Field.

The Pumpkin Field

-- An Army Lieutenant observes the Cherokees he guards on their passage to the west, Arkansas 1838

What a grand lot they were,
the Cherokees I first saw in June,
lined up in their Georgian camp
to greet the chief on their departure,
elegant blankets hanging loose
about their shoulders, ramrod-straight,
dark eyes darting from high-boned
copper faces under bright turbans
and striped caps pulled down at an angle,
some in long robes, some in tunics,
all with sashes or wondrous drapery,
they stood, framed by bearded oaks,
Old Testament patriarchs
pausing on their way to the Promised Land.

Then in October, where I'd been sent ahead

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to patrol their passage here in Arkansas,
they came from a cold and threadbare wood,
thin pines bent and tipped with sleet,
eyes glazed and blank,
half-naked, barefoot,
bones poking through
their scarecrow shredded clothing,
and stumbled through layers of mist
onto a scraggly open field
where in wet and tangled grass
fat pumpkins lay in rows
like painted severed heads.

Oblivious to all around them,
skeletal automatons,
the Cherokees plunged ahead
until a farmer on the edge
bade them halt
and, breaking off a pumpkin,
invited them to take
whatever his poor field could offer.

Flies swarming to their target,
they darted up and down the rows,
black hair flying,
long-nailed tentacles
protruding, they ripped apart
the pumpkin flesh
until their brown and vacant
faces merged with jagged pulp,
seeds foaming from

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their hungry mouths, and all I could see,
as on some battlefield, was
everywhere a wasted mass of orange flesh.

A light rain then began to fall
as if the shredded pumpkin fiber
drifted down around us:
I felt ill
and sensed that cholera
had set in. The farmer guided
me inside his cabin
and put me down in a dark corner
where between the logs
I could empty my stomach.

All night long I lay there
while wind roared
and rain beat down
and through it I could hear the sloshing
of the weary feet,
the creak and rattle of ox-carts,
the cursing of the drivers,
cracking their long whips to urge the oxen on,
the whinnying of horses
as they struggled through the mud.

"What have we done to these people?"
I cried out ... And then a silence fell;
across the dark I saw
row after row of pumpkins carved and slit,
their crooked eyes

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and pointed teeth all candle-lit within,
not pumpkins but death's-heads they were
with features of the vacant
hungry faces I had seen,
stretching to infinity
and glowing in the dark-
and glowing still when I awoke-

as they do now, and as they always will.

TRANSITION

There were ten million Native Americans on this continent when the first non-Indians arrived. Over the next 300 years, 90% of the Native American population was wiped out by disease, famine, or warfare imported by the whites. By 1840 all the eastern tribes had been subdued, annihilated or forcibly removed to Indian Territory west of the Mississippi. This is the . . . . Song of the Dispossessed

Song of the Dispossessed

You came across the water,
like gods you walked ashore
the fabric of our dreaming
was the clothing that you wore.

You came with ornament
far brighter than the sun;
you brought the handsome horse,
the flashing blade, the gun.

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You brought your holy book
that held a world entire,
a life that never ended;
and water that was fire.

You said, "We'll live as brothers,
as brothers we will die;
we'll share the forest carpet
and the blanket of the sky."

But then when we came near you,
you said "Now move away;
you come too close now, brother,
it's dangerous to stay

so close to one another;
and you must understand
that we know what is better –
we'll send you to a land

far richer in the west
beyond the great brown river
where grass is always green
and there you'll live forever."

And so you took our country,
you took our sacred ground,
the birds and beasts we cherished,
the falling water's sound,

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the stag that with his antlers
breaks the sun-flecked trail,
the mockingbird, the turkey,
the heron and the quail.

You sent us to this desert,
this sand, these pitted stones,
where wind rakes through the gully
and bares the bison's bones,

where now above this barren earth
your great bald eagle screams,
that robbed us of our country
and carried off our dreams.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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